Myanmar government, among them the Mon, Kayin, Kayah and Shan ethnic groups. Hundreds of thousands of refugees and migrants from these groups have also sought sanctuary in Thailand. They tend to do low-paid jobs in the Thai economy, often under parlous conditions. This workforce is especially evident in borderland provinces where people who once lived in Myanmar provide much of the labour for manufacturing, agriculture and fishing. Myanmar's long history of displacement has created a new underclass in Thai society, ripe for exploitation by callous economic and political interests.

A different type of manipulation on the Myanmar side has kept these border wars in a perpetually unfinished state. Since the ceasefire agreements first emerged, particularly during the spurt of enthusiastic negotiations in the 1980s and 1990s, the country has endured stop-start progress towards final peace agreements. It does not help that trust in the government is patchy, as explained by Welsh and Huang in this volume. Nonetheless, when the Thein Sein government took power in 2011 it redoubled official peace-making efforts under the guise of the Myanmar Peace Center (MPC). Its mandate, to further diminish the level of conflict around the country, was entrusted to Aung Min, a government minister, who became the preferred negotiator (for details see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume). Aung Min worked closely with MPC staff to create conditions for a nationwide ceasefire agreement. While similar initiatives in the 1990s had failed, there was hope that the MPC could generate a more comprehensive and long-lasting peace deal. Negotiations with the different armed groups were slow and, in the end, the agreement signed in October 2015 only included a fraction of the country's major fighting forces. The key point of contention was reluctance to accept a resolution to conflict in the absence of a durable political structure that would offer sufficient autonomy to ethnic groups. The UWSA and KIA were among the major groups that decided to stay out of the deal. They were no doubt motivated not to participate by the idea that, before long, they would be negotiating with a different government entirely.

POLITICS

The NLD won a resounding victory at the 8 November 2015 general election (Thawngmung 2016b; Chaw Chaw Sein, this volume). Its win changes the equation for conflict in Myanmar in many ways. For a start, the new government does not have a track record on which it is possible